relationship, freed from the encumbrances of the past. Therefore, they proceeded determinedly in that direction, successfully addressing the domestic political challenges to that process. This was also a moment when authoritative US studies focussed more strongly on the global relevance of India's human resources. Pretty much across the board, cooperative trends gathered momentum in a positive atmosphere. It was visible in defence, civil aviation, science and technology, trade and mobility.

The successful conclusion of the India–US nuclear deal widened the pathway to greater shared endeavours. That five successive American presidents, who were so different from each other, have been united in their pursuit of better ties with India has been a real game-changer. This consistency holds true at the Indian end as well. As a result, a relationship that was earlier notable for its argumentation and distancing has undergone a sea change.

There are many ways of capturing the transformation that has been underway for more than a decade. Trade is one obvious indicator, and it has expanded fivefold in the last 15 years. Investment is much harder to accurately define in national terms, but it has clearly multiplied in this period. The flow of talent is relevant because technology forms such a key element of the ties. The H category of visas, which enabled techies to move between the two countries, almost doubled in the last decade-and-a-half. So, too, has the number of students from India.

In some domains, this progress can be expressed through decisions and agreements. That a country that bought no American defence platforms from 1965 for four decades should now operate C-130, C-17 and P-8 aircraft, as well as Apache, Chinook and MH-60R helicopters, is not a mean achievement. Indeed, the security dimension of the relationship should be judged by more than defence trade. Policy exchanges and military exercises also testify to this shift, as do the multiple agreements that promote closer coordination. The mechanisms and dialogues today span a very wide range of subjects, from counter-terrorism and cyber security to climate action and energy, from space cooperation and health to education and homeland security.

What has changed further is that while the focus till 2014 was to remove obstacles to cooperation, the endeavour after that has been to ambitiously realize its expanding potential. Prime Minister Modi's 2023 State visit to the US, in that sense, marks a new phase of ties. The expanding agenda of